

DECEMBER 2025

East Passyunk

PAST, PRESENT, AND FUTURE

PRESENTED BY

Daniel Rhondeau

Gavin Defina

Katie Knox

Milan Brito

Zhuosi Yang



UNIVERSITY OF
PENNSYLVANIA

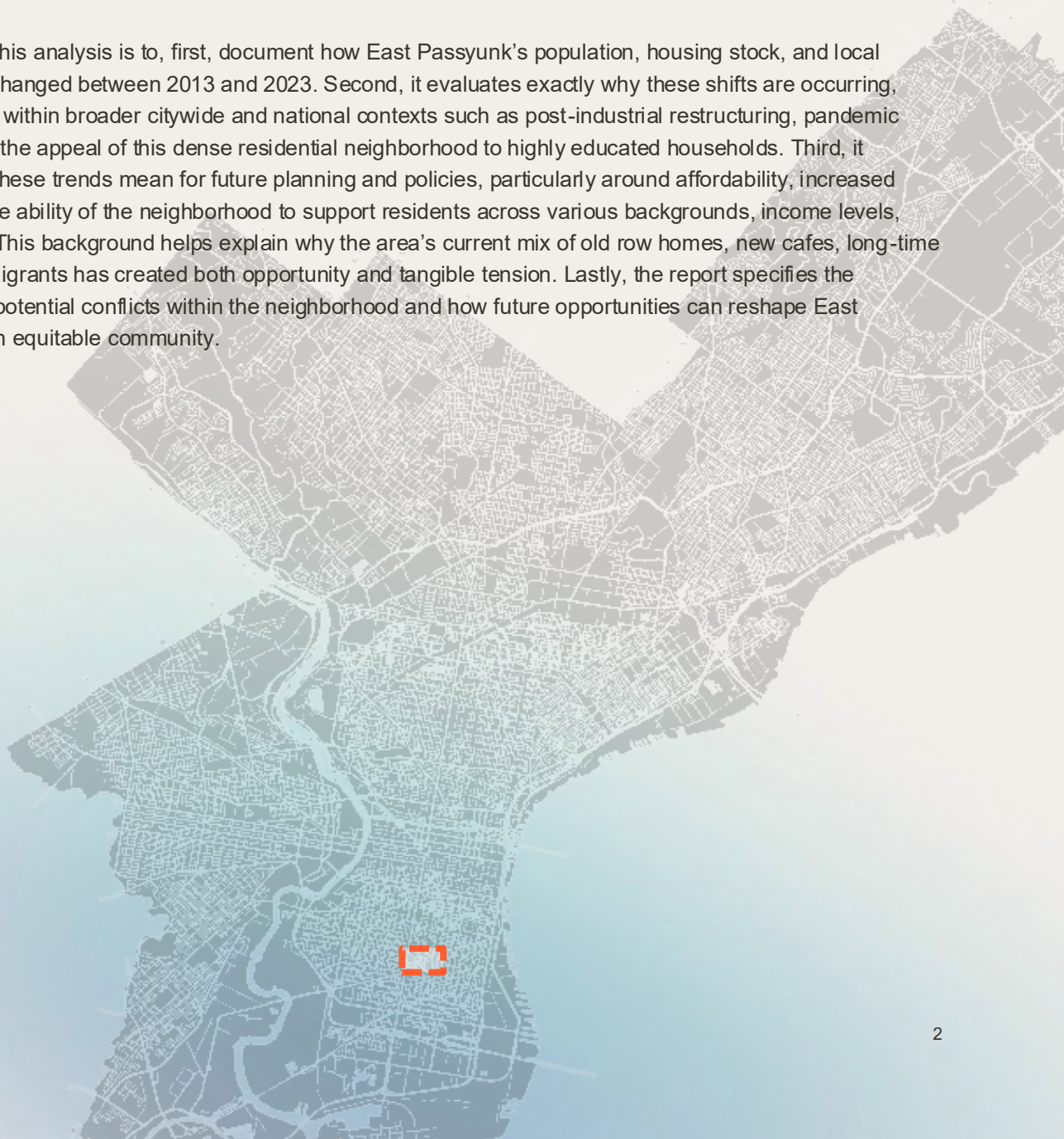
Table of Contents

2	Executive Summary	13	Hidden Housing Change
3	Geographic Context	18	An Avenue for Dining, Shopping, and Services
4	History	27	Challenges and Opportunities
5	Valley of Millennial Dreams	30	References

Executive Summary

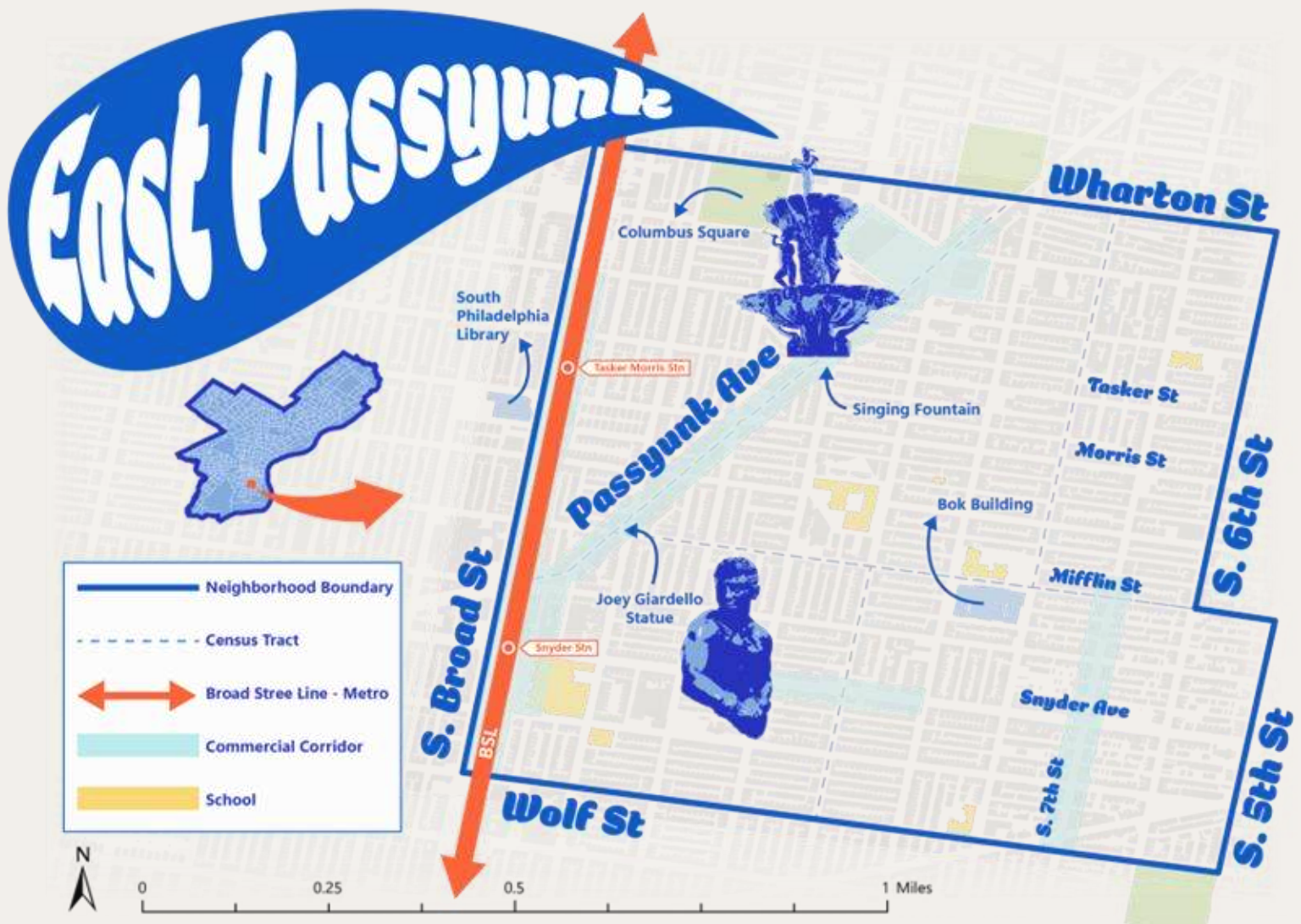
East Passyunk stands at an important inflection point. Its history of immigration, strong working-class culture, and neighborhood pride provide context for understanding the rapid demographic, social, economic, and housing changes that are underway. Over the past decade, it appears as though not much has changed in the neighborhood from a visual perspective: racial makeup and housing trends have largely maintained, and many of the changes that have occurred seem to be continuations of phenomena already occurring in 2013. Yet the less-visible changes in the social fabric of the neighborhood—through the entrance of young adults with and without children, the proliferation of higher incomes and education, and the increase of housing prices—have given the area both a new identity and new challenges, especially for long-time residents who fall outside of these categories.

The purpose of this analysis is to, first, document how East Passyunk's population, housing stock, and local economy have changed between 2013 and 2023. Second, it evaluates exactly why these shifts are occurring, comparing them within broader citywide and national contexts such as post-industrial restructuring, pandemic disruptions, and the appeal of this dense residential neighborhood to highly educated households. Third, it considers what these trends mean for future planning and policies, particularly around affordability, increased inclusion, and the ability of the neighborhood to support residents across various backgrounds, income levels, and life stages. This background helps explain why the area's current mix of old row homes, new cafes, long-time residents, and migrants has created both opportunity and tangible tension. Lastly, the report specifies the challenges and potential conflicts within the neighborhood and how future opportunities can reshape East Passyunk into an equitable community.



Geography

East Passyunk is located in the southern region of Philadelphia, composed of five census tracts: 40.01, 41.01, 28.01, 28.02, 29. The neighborhood is bordered by South Broad Street to the west, Wolf Street to the south, Wharton Street to the north, and South 5th/6th Street to the east. This neighborhood is anchored by the East Passyunk Avenue commercial corridor, which runs diagonally through the neighborhood and functions as its primary commercial and social spine, connecting residential blocks to transit, employment centers, and adjacent neighborhoods.



History

The original delineation of East Passyunk Avenue, the heart of the neighborhood, was first used as a migratory trail by the Lenape tribe. The indigenous population named the area “Passyunk,” meaning “in the valley,” a place that has connected different communities together over time within the bustling corridor-based neighborhood. “Passyunk predates Center City and almost everything else” as Swedish immigrants started to settle in the neighborhood in the 17th century and established a treaty of shared land with the Lenape people (Dent, 2015).

South Philadelphia neighborhoods, like East Passyunk, joined the larger Philadelphia city after the passing of the Consolidation Act of 1854. Throughout the 19th century, waves of immigrants from Sweden, Ireland, Eastern Europe, and Italy helped establish the neighborhood of East Passyunk. The immigrant population formed a highly developed commercial and social setting, contributing to the rich cultural fabric seen today.

In the early 20th century, East Passyunk was influenced by Italian heritage, as seen in the East Passyunk Historical Street Scenes mural by Jared Bader showing the temporal change of the 9th Street and Passyunk Avenue intersection. East Passyunk, like much of Philadelphia County, began to see a population decline and disinvestment between the 1960s and 1970s, as a disappearance of manufacturing jobs and suburbanization reshaped the region. However, its older housing stock, walkable layout, and established institutions made it possible to maintain a sense of continuity.

At the end of the 20th century, East Passyunk grown into a hub of interconnectedness in Philadelphia from new immigrant communities coming from Latin America and Southeast Asia. In 2002, the East Passyunk Avenue Business Improvement District (BID) was established to help revitalize and preserve Philadelphia’s longest-standing commercial corridor. This non-profit organization, in collaboration with Passyunk Avenue Revitalization Corporation and the East Passyunk Crossing Civic Association, is focused on business development, public safety, and neighborhood beautification. Throughout the last two decades, the neighborhood has experienced a new wave of interest from young professionals and small business owners, especially along the popular East Passyunk Avenue commercial corridor.

This revitalization, which is often viewed as both a positive economic rebirth and a form of class and social friction, has raised home values and attracted new residents, while also being a center of debate on general affordability and identity. With this background in mind, the following analysis looks at how the neighborhood’s demographics, housing patterns, and socio-economic characteristics have shifted in the last decade, between 2013 and 2023, and what East Passyunk should expect for future changes and growth.



Valley of Millennial Dreams

In East Passyunk, there is a greater presence of highly educated young professionals who are either living by themselves or starting new families. Simultaneously, there is a diminishing and vanishing presence of an immigrant and foreign-born population stronghold the neighborhood is historically used to obtaining.

Overall Population Change

Since 2010, East Passyunk has had mixed cycles of increasing and declining neighborhood populations (Figure 1). The neighborhood had the largest decline of 2,400 people from 2020 to 2021, presumably from the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic. Currently, East Passyunk is experiencing a post-pandemic rebound in population.

However, in the past decade, the East Passyunk neighborhood has had a slight decrease of 313 residents since 2013; a differing trend when compared to Philadelphia's 3% population growth. The neighborhood experienced increases from the Millennial (35-to-44) and Generation Alpha (under 5) aged populations while older residents, teenagers, and young adults decreased. This large increase in young professionals and new families is helping stabilize the East Passyunk population from further decline and is supporting the rebound growth in the post-pandemic era. In the past decade, the 15-to-24 and 75 and above age groups experienced significant population losses, while the 35-to-44 age group increased by 1,700 people (and by 7 percentage points), and the under-5 age group increased by 250 people or 15% growth. The changing age composition of East Passyunk is more prevalent within the neighborhood than across Philadelphia.

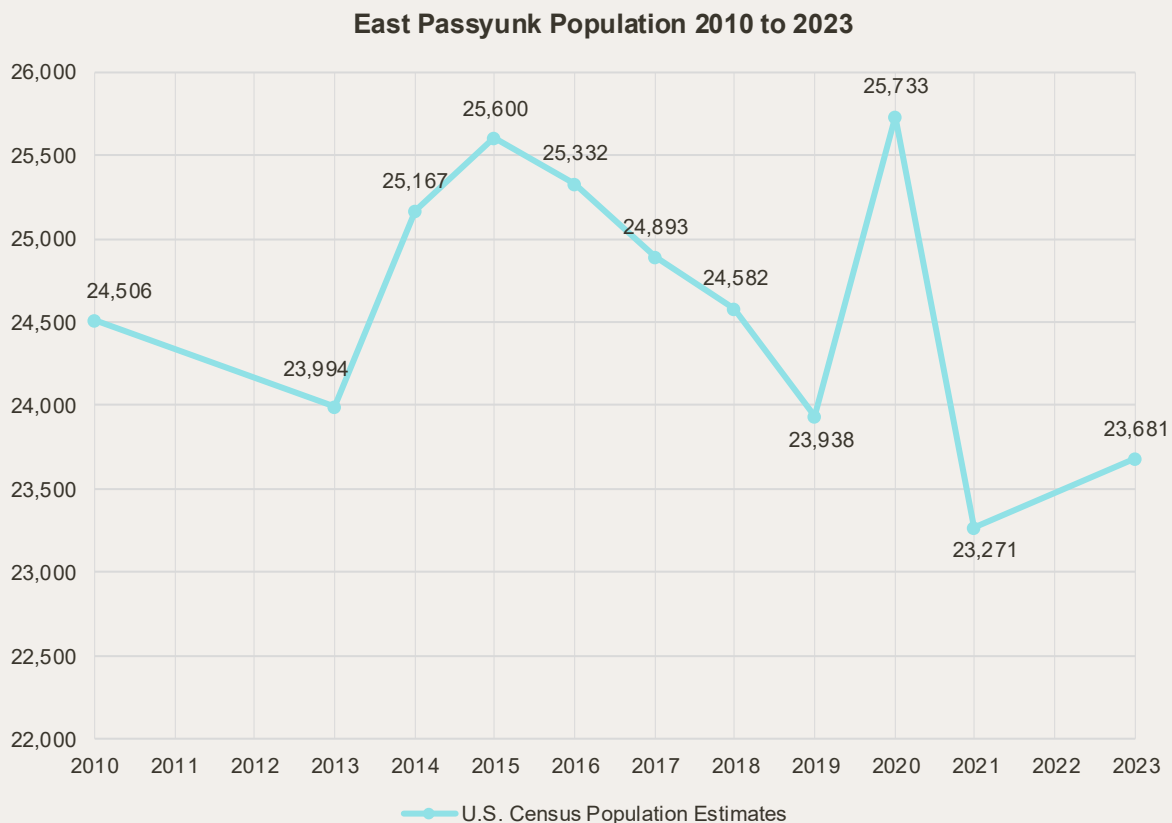


Figure 1

Age Composition

The Millennial (35-to-44) and Gen Alpha (under 5) age groups are more concentrated in East Passyunk than in Philadelphia: 1.5 location quotient and 1.26 location quotient, respectively. A location quotient is a measure of how concentrated a population is in East Passyunk compared to Philadelphia. On the other hand, subsequent young children age groups are experiencing major decreases as the 5-to-9 age cohort is decreasing by 400 (-34% change). This relates to the potential phenomenon of families and guardians moving to the suburbs when children reach an older age. Additionally, the population of 75 and above is decreasing by 750 residents. The older population in East Passyunk is decreasing, while in comparison is growing in Philadelphia. The ages of 5-24 in the population are all less concentrated in East Passyunk than in Philadelphia with location quotients less than 0.75.

2013 Population Pyramid

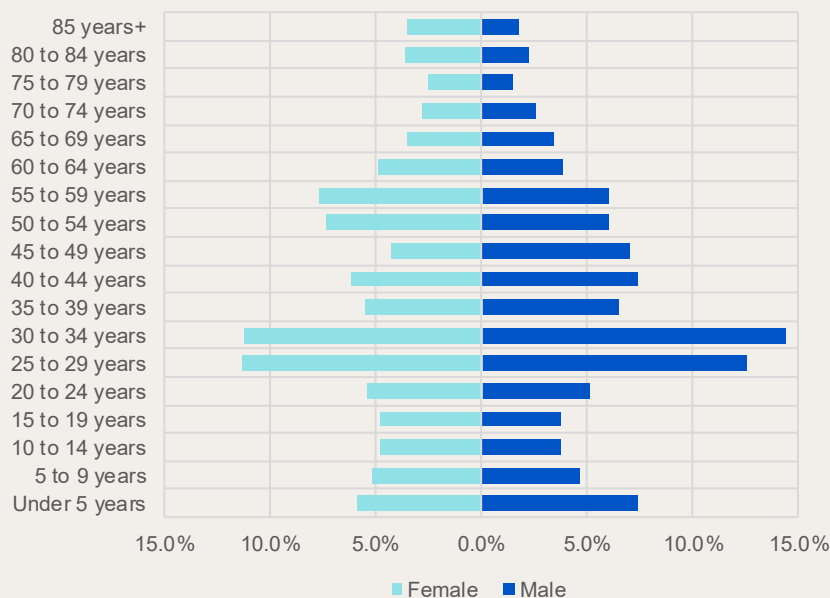


Figure 2

2023 Population Pyramid

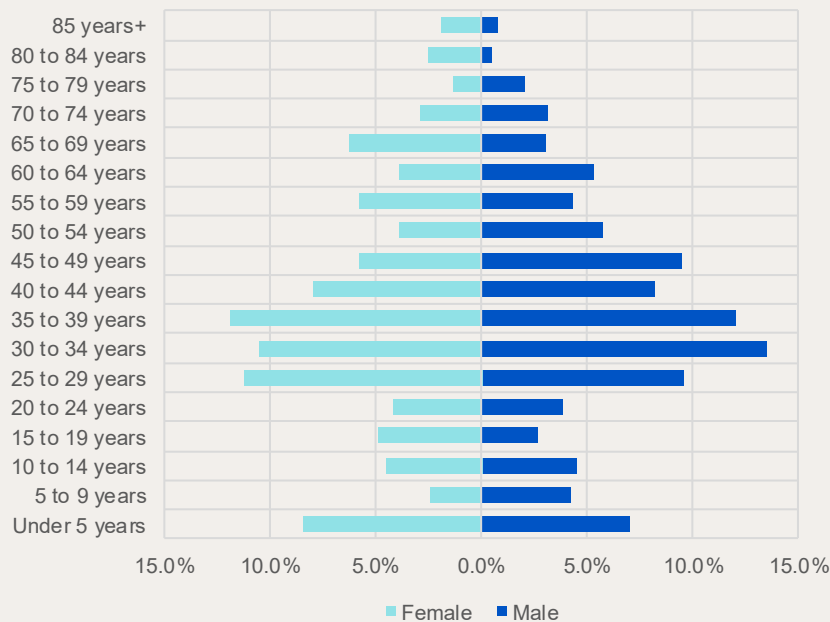


Figure 3

Education & School Enrollment

East Passyunk is becoming more highly educated. Over half of the East Passyunk population has a bachelor's degree, compared to Philadelphia's 35%. The neighborhood increased in higher education prowess as the population with a bachelor's degree increased by 2,700 and 15 percentage points, while those with a graduate or professional degree increased by 2,000 and 11 percentage points from 2013. East Passyunk has a higher concentration of those with higher education degrees than Philadelphia: 1.55 location quotient for bachelor's degree earners and 1.36 location quotient for graduate degree earners.

East Passyunk is facing declining school enrollment for kindergarten to college levels, while seeing a spike in nursery and preschool enrollment. This decline in school enrollment could be attributed to the decline in the overall neighborhood population. The nursery school and preschool neighborhood enrollment increased by 43% since 2013 and is 2.65 times more concentrated than Philadelphia. This surge of nursery and preschool enrollment can be attributed to the start of new family formation in the neighborhood by Millennial-aged parents.

Education and school enrollment changes are shaping East Passyunk into a neighborhood where young adults with increasingly high educational attainment are starting families and shifting the neighborhood school enrollment's focus to a growing cohort of pre-school and nursery school students.

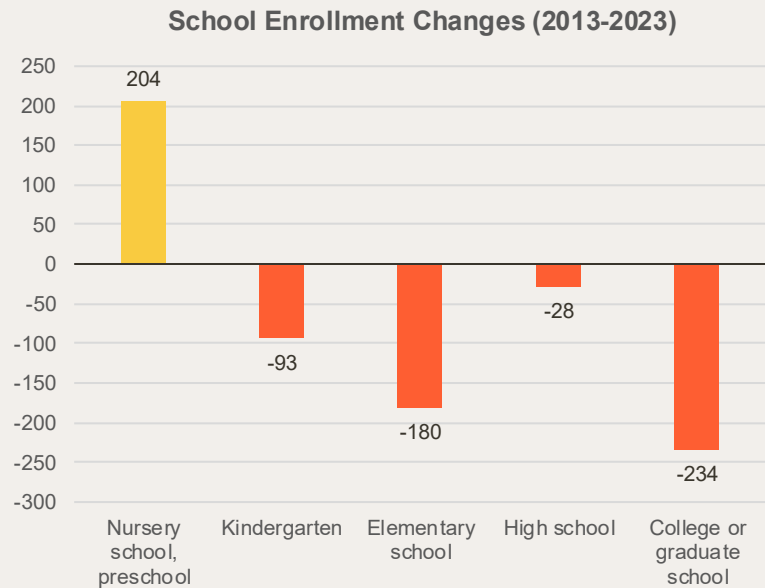


Figure 4

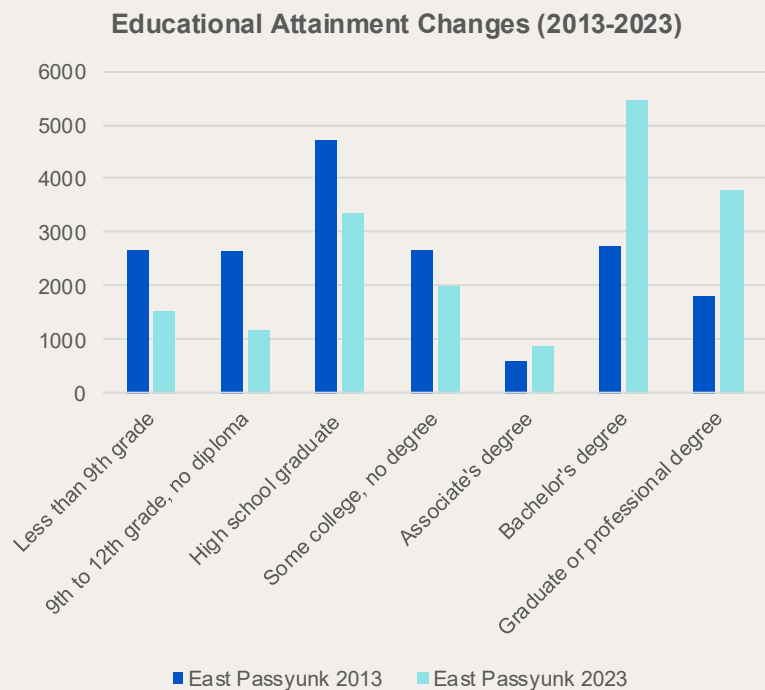


Figure 5

Household Formation

In East Passyunk, single householders are moving into the neighborhood with an overall increase of 1,150 total households, while family size and married couple households are declining. Married couple households had a 1,200 decrease (-24% change), while male and female householders with no partner both experienced a 1,750 increase each. However, married couple households still have the highest composition of household formations in 2023 at 36% followed by female householders with no partner at 29%. male householders with no partner at 22%, and 14% of cohabiting couple households which also decreased by 1,600 households.

Although young families continue to form, families are getting smaller as reflected in the 3.18 median family size in 2013, which has decreased to 2.8 in 2023. Despite this decrease, young children and married couples have gained a stronger presence in the neighborhood and are more concentrated in East Passyunk by a factor of 1.4, which is the result of a decrease in married-couple households in Philadelphia. Additionally, 22% of all households in East Passyunk with one or more people under 18 slightly increased in the past decade, showcasing the strength of the under-5 age group growth.

East Passyunk's increase of Millennial professionals is shifting the neighborhood's household composition. As residents with no partner increases, coupled households have decreased. A historic family-oriented neighborhood is disappearing as multigenerational households and families decline, while varying types of non-family structures, such as single householders, increase.

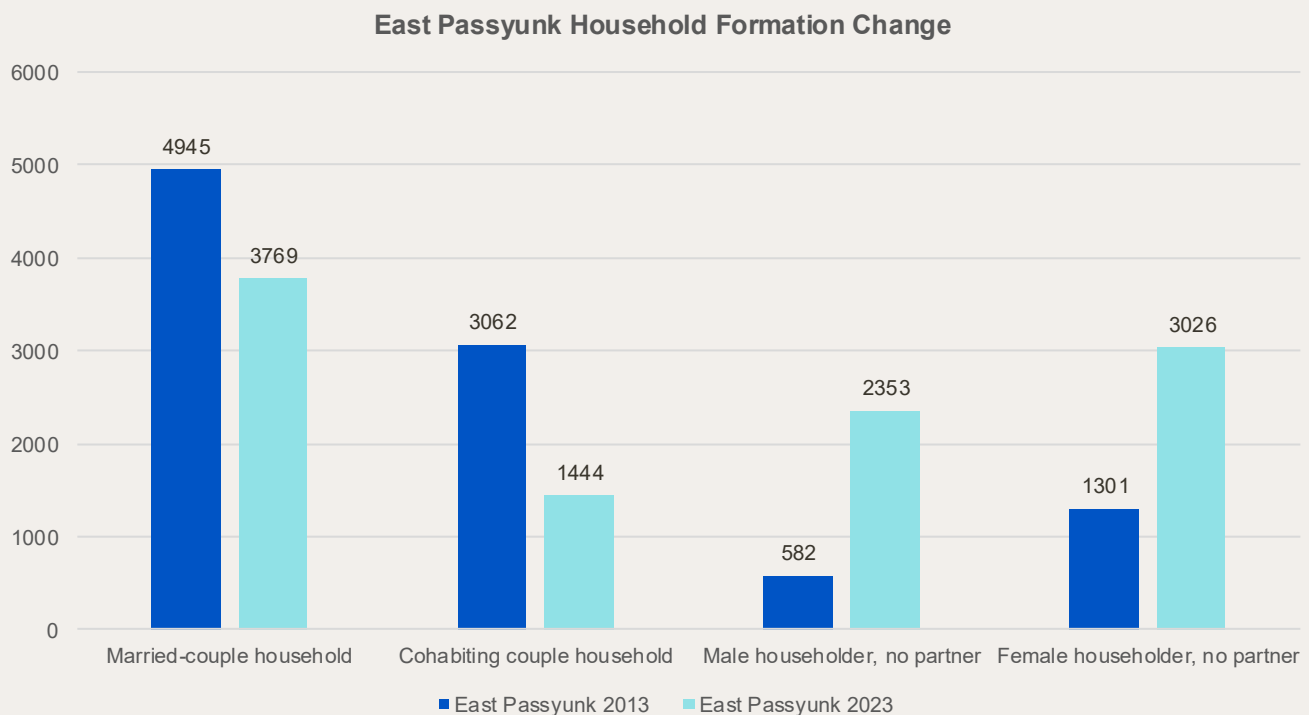


Figure 6

Race

East Passyunk's racial composition is reported as less diverse than Philadelphia. East Passyunk's population is majority white (59%), Asian (18%), mixed-race (10%), and Black population (6%). The white population is 1.6 times more concentrated in East Passyunk, while the Black population is less concentrated by a factor of 0.16. Additionally, there is a higher concentration of the Asian population in East Passyunk by a factor of 2.34, specifically with a strong Chinese subpopulation; however, their presence is declining. There is a considerable decrease in the Asian population, with a -1,500 decrease in residents from the Other Asian, Filipino, and Vietnamese populations.

East Passyunk's population is 16% Hispanic or Latino, which reports as Mexican, Other Hispanic, or Latino. The population is gradually increasing over time with a 2.5 percentage point change and has a higher yet shrinking concentration of the Mexican population than Philadelphia, with a location quotient of 4.77 (decreasing from 7.95 in 2013).

East Passyunk's lack of diversity and diminishing non-white populations causes concern, specifically with the decrease of the neighborhood's Asian population.

Racial Composition in Philadelphia and East Passyunk 2023

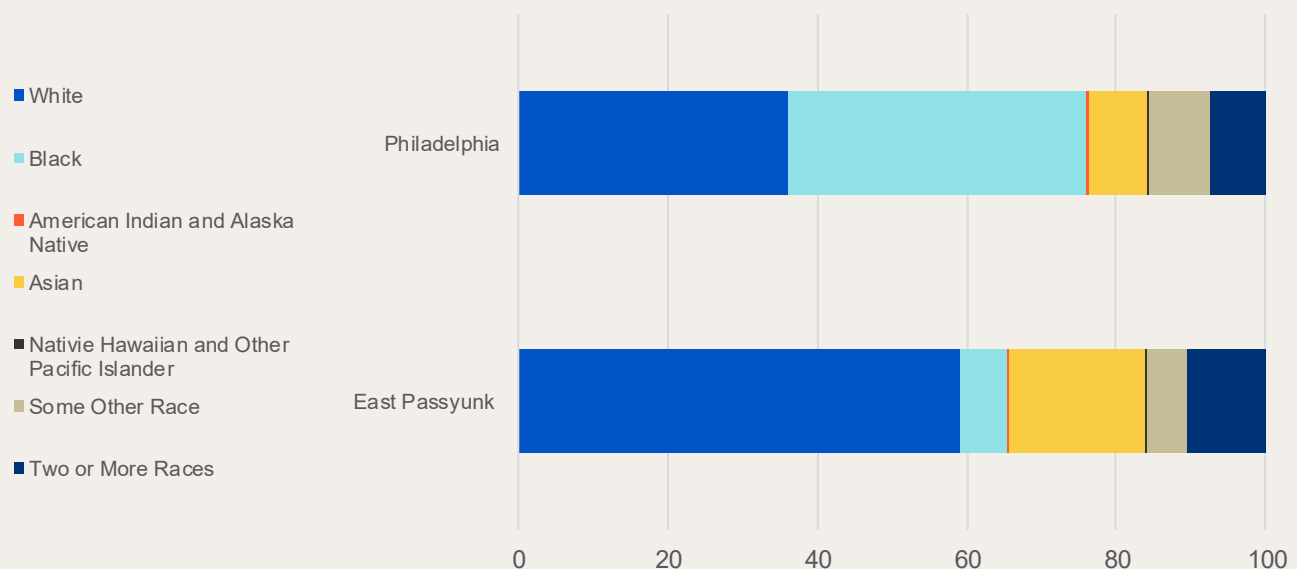


Figure 7

Foreign-Born Population

Long-time foreign-born residents are moving out of East Passyunk. Twenty-two percent of East Passyunk, or a total of 6,680, are foreign-born residents, 77% of whom entered the United States before 2010. Immigrants mainly come from Asia (57%), Latin America (27%), and Europe (8%). This matches the overall racial and ethnic demographics of the neighborhood.

The foreign-born population in East Passyunk has decreased by over 1,400 residents (-22% change), mostly from the decrease of Asian immigrants and those who immigrated to the neighborhood before 2010 (18 percentage point decrease). East Passyunk, once known to be an immigrant-rooted neighborhood in Philadelphia, is becoming less so over time as the location quotient of immigrants decreases from 2.28 in 2013 to 1.50 in 2023. Similarly, East Passyunk is acknowledged as a historical Italian American community, yet the population with Italian ancestry has decreased from 43% in 2000 to 22% in 2023.

Reflected in English literacy trends, specifically in households that speak languages other than English, Asian languages make up 47% of this group, and Spanish-speakers make up 40%. English proficiency is relatively low in East Passyunk. Of Asian language speakers, 73% have low English proficiency. Of Spanish speakers, 52% have low English proficiency. Even though English speaking has improved overall—since the number of all individuals with low English proficiency has decreased by 9% from 2013 to 2023—this population is still more concentrated in East Passyunk than in Philadelphia by a factor of 1.6. Since English proficiency impacts academic and occupational success in the United States, those who are not proficient have a distinct disadvantage compared to those who are.

Foreign-born residents are still more economically disadvantaged than the native population, as they have a higher proportion of residents living below the poverty level in the past decade. East Passyunk's overall population is experiencing less poverty conditions in 2023 than in 2013, but in 2023, 21% of the foreign-born population is facing poverty hardship compared to 13% of the native-born population.

East Passyunk must develop improved opportunities, resources, and services to support its declining foreign-born population. It appears as if social programs and resources are not effectively supporting this group, perhaps because immigration from non-English-speaking countries is less of a contemporary phenomenon than it previously was within the neighborhood. East Passyunk may want to consider providing more literacy and education resources for immigrants and individuals with low English proficiency.



Population Projection

To calculate future population growth in East Passyunk, step-down models and linear regression were utilized.

For the Step-Down Models, Philadelphia is used as a reference geography to project East Passyunk's population in 2030. Population estimates from the 2010 and 2020 Decennial Censuses were utilized to provide an accurate and optimistic growth estimate for 2030. This created three step-down population projections: Most Recent Constant Share projection of 26,987, Average Share projection of 26,999, and Most Recent Growth Share projection of 26,966. Since all three of these projections estimate population figures were within 40 residents, the median estimate was selected as an optimistic forecast.

In context of the Linear Regression model, population estimates were used from the ACS and Decennial Census estimates from 2010 to 2023 to project East Passyunk's population in 2030. Some of the ACS neighborhood population estimates are not accurate. The estimates for 2011, 2012, and 2022 produced inaccurate results where the neighborhood seemingly would have declined in population by over 10,000 residents; only years with more accurate estimates were included. The linear regression produces a negative trend line to create a pessimistic projection of 23,693.

Issue with both projections are present in the context of recent population-changing events. The optimistic projection does not account for the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic when the population declined from 2020 to 2021. And the pessimistic projection does not account for the potential population rebound from the COVID-19 pandemic, where East Passyunk saw an increase of 410 residents from 2021 to 2023.

This report uses the optimistic projection for future employment and housing projections in East Passyunk.

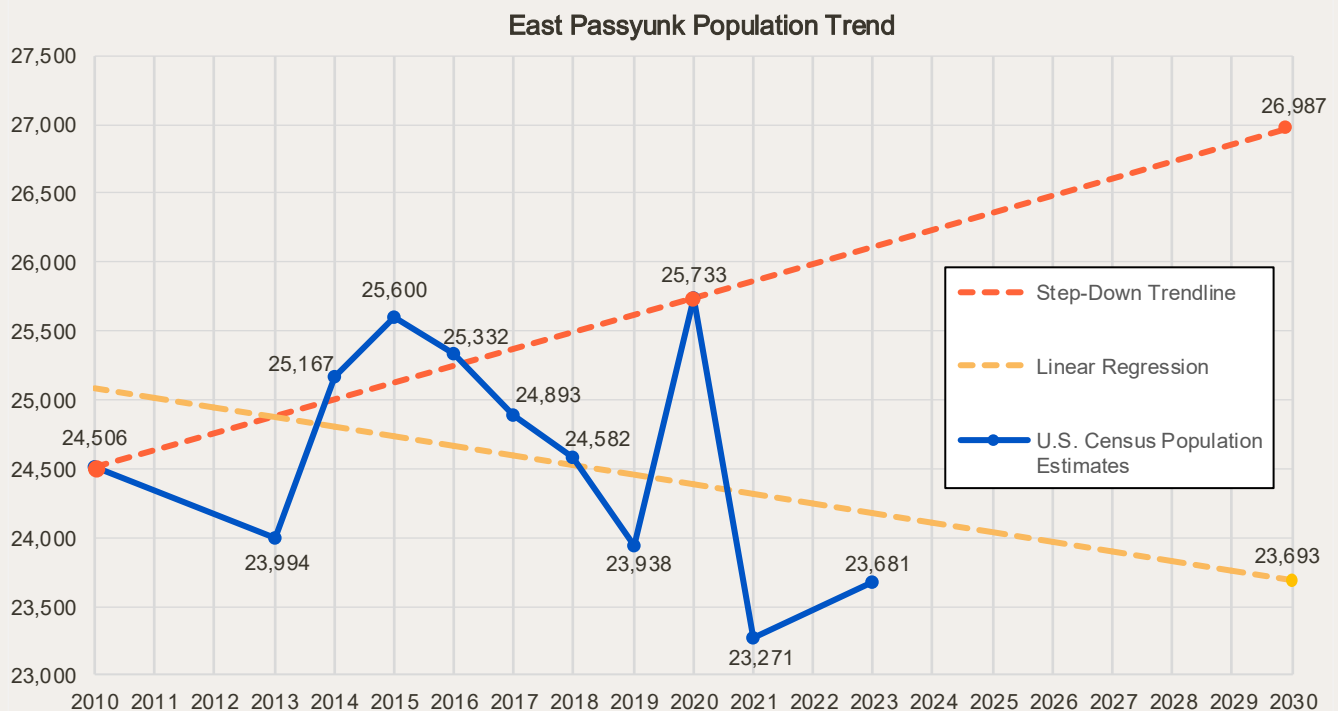


Figure 8

Hidden Housing Change

Most of the housing changes that have occurred in East Passyunk are not too apparent from the outside. It seems as if not much has changed in the neighborhood over the years: housing stock is old, and there has been little growth in housing stock overall. However, housing statistics reveal an increasingly unaffordable neighborhood.

Housing At A Glance

There are 10,592 occupied housing units in East Passyunk, with an occupancy rate of 93%. Housing structures in the neighborhood are largely made up of old rowhomes, with 64% of East Passyunk's entire housing stock built before 1939, and 69% of structures being one-unit attached houses. Compared to Philadelphia, housing built before 1939 is more concentrated in the neighborhood by a factor of 1.6, further reinforcing the historic character of the neighborhood. There are very few multi-unit structures, as only 24% of the housing stock is multi-unit. This reflects the status of East Passyunk as a historically family-oriented neighborhood.

Increasing Households, Steady Population

Although the total population of East Passyunk stayed relatively stable, the number of households grew from 9,446 to 10,592—a 12% increase.

With this growth in households, most of the residents of East Passyunk are newcomers: 70% moved to the neighborhood after 2010, and 40% moved in the last five years, compared to 61% and 34% respectively of Philadelphians at large. Additionally, the composition of Philadelphians who moved into their residence before 1989 has decreased at a slower pace than that of East Passyunk (-10.4% vs -12.1%). The share of people aging in place in East Passyunk is less than in Philadelphia at large.

East Passyunk is becoming an attractive Philadelphia neighborhood for out-of-state movers, as the out-of-state migration is greater than the immigration from residents coming from within Philadelphia. In terms of intra-city immigration to East Passyunk, the 1-to-4 and 35-to-39 age groups had the largest increase. The Millennial and young children's population are moving to East Passyunk and staying in their residences longer than other age groups and more than they would a decade ago. Overall, these young adults and young families are putting their roots down in East Passyunk.

A steady population with an increase in households demonstrates that the demographic fabric of the neighborhood is changing, with a prominent small family size and young adult community emerging in the neighborhood in recent years. At the same time, long-time residents are moving out.



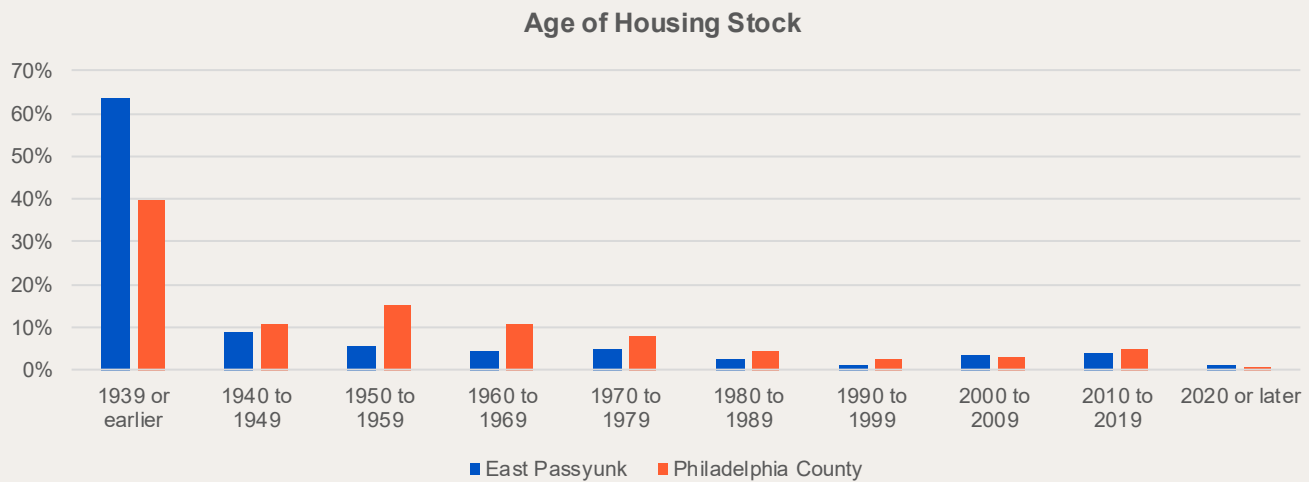


Figure 9

Housing Stock

Housing has only increased by 5% since 2013, from 10,812 to 11,417 total units (occupied and vacant), and this is driven by the subdivision of older units. Units in buildings built between 1940 and 1999 increased by 25%. New, large-scale apartments have been built, with a 107% increase in housing structures of 20 units or more since 2013, but this only makes up 3% of the total housing stock. Through subdivision and—to a lesser degree—new construction, housing has increased in response to the growing number of households in the neighborhood, but not at a fast enough rate (5% growth in housing stock versus 12% growth in households).

Subdivision of older apartments is often associated with renovation. Many households have converted from gas heating to electric heating in the past ten years, both in Philadelphia and East Passyunk, but East Passyunk outpaces Philadelphia. Energy conversion could be the result of state tax credits encouraging heat pump adoptions, and policies like this that incentivize home upgrades should have an eye toward this neighborhood, given its high share of very old buildings.

Housing Value

Housing has become more expensive. In 2013, the upper end of the median home value in East Passyunk was \$324,789 (in 2023 dollars). In 2023, this number grew to \$422,100, a 23% increase over the 10-year period.

Looking at the entire range of median home values across the five Census tracts, the median home value is between \$273,699 and \$422,100. Despite this wide range, East Passyunk as a whole is more expensive than Philadelphia. The city has a median home value of \$232,400, which means housing in East Passyunk is 15% to 45% more expensive.

Home value and home affordability are not the same thing, and this is largely dependent on the financial characteristics of residents. In East Passyunk, residents have distinct experiences based on their tenure.

Homeowners

Sixty percent of residents in East Passyunk are owners, an increase of 3 percentage points from 2013. Thirty-three percent of homeowners have a mortgage. This is another feature of newer residents moving into the area, since new homebuyers are more likely to have a mortgage to afford a home, and non-mortgage-holding homeowners are more likely to be long-time residents.

Median monthly housing costs reveal that homeowners pay between \$1,697 and \$2,250 per month for their mortgage plus other costs. The Census data on homeowners' median incomes is not granular enough at the neighborhood scale, so affordability can be ascertained from looking at monthly owner costs as a percentage of household income. Only 25% of homeowners are cost-burdened, meaning that over 30% of their income goes toward housing costs. This means that the majority of homeowners (75%) are not cost-burdened. These numbers have improved since 2013, when 32% of homeowners were cost-burdened, a 7-percentage point decrease in 2023.

Renters

Forty percent of residents in East Passyunk are renters. This share is decreasing as the neighborhood is shifting towards more homeowners. The decreasing size of this group highlights important inequalities in the East Passyunk housing market between homeowners and renters.

Renters pay between \$1,381 and \$1,605 per month in rent, and 58% are not rent-burdened. Similar to homeowners, the percentage of renters who are rent-burdened has decreased from 54% in 2013 to 42% in 2023. Across the neighborhood, it appears as if East Passyunk is becoming more affordable for residents.

However, the devil is in the details, as the income inequality of East Passyunk clearly demonstrates. The rich are becoming richer, while those who are less wealthy are left behind. In terms of households occupied by renters, about 88% of people who make below \$50,000 (already less than Philadelphia's current median income of \$60,098) are rent-burdened. In 2013, 78% of people who made below \$35,000 (less than Philadelphia's 2013 median income of \$37,192) were rent-burdened—an increase of 10 percentage points over the 10-year period. Compared to Philadelphia, where only 76% of renters making less than the median income are rent-burdened, East Passyunk is not an affordable place to live for its lower-income residents.

These inequalities in housing are primarily due to a lack of affordable housing in the area. As certain incomes rise more than others, those who are making comparatively less are potentially being priced out of the neighborhood.

Housing Projection

In 2030, we predict a need for more housing. Based on our optimistic population projection, there will be 12,071 households in 2030. East Passyunk needs to build 1,479 new housing units to keep up with growth. From 2013 to 2023, 605 housing units were built, for an annual rate of 61 housing units per year. To meet 2030 projected housing demand, East Passyunk will need to build 211 housing units per year—a 71% increase from previous years.

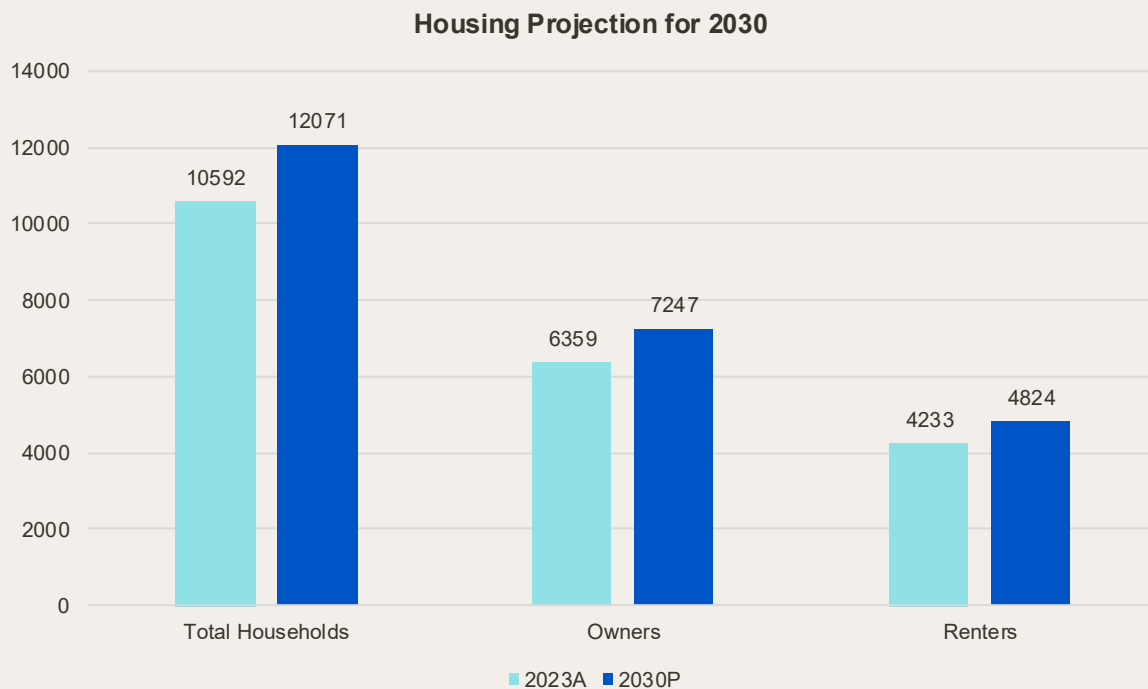


Figure 10

East Passyunk's stagnant housing production must be confronted to address rapidly changing housing needs.

An Avenue for Dining, Shopping, and Services

East Passyunk is a rapidly evolving economy, driven by the efforts of business associations that promote small businesses. However, existing wealth inequalities among residents and workers in East Passyunk could be further exacerbated if measures are not taken to retain affordable options for all.

Employment Sectors

In 2022, two-thirds of jobs in East Passyunk were in four sectors, based on the North American Industry Classification System: Health Care and Social Assistance (Sector 62), Accommodation and Food Services (Sector 72), Retail Trade (Sector 44), and Administrative and Support and Waste Management and Remediation Services (Sector 56). These types of jobs are very high in Philadelphia overall, especially in Sector 62, painting East Passyunk as a microcosm of the city's economy. However, absolute employment numbers do not tell the whole story.

The basic industries in East Passyunk differ markedly from those in Philadelphia. Basic industries are those in which East Passyunk has a higher percentage of jobs than Philadelphia, indicating relative competitiveness in these sectors. Philadelphia's basic industries, compared to the US at large, are Health Care and Social Assistance, Educational Services (Sector 61), and Arts, Entertainment, and Recreation (Sector 71)—i.e., “eds and meds” and tourism. East Passyunk's are Construction (Sector 23), Other Services (Sector 81), Sector 44, Sector 56, and Sector 72, mentioned previously. This indicates that consumers seek East Passyunk for construction workers, shopping, dining, and other services, including salons, funeral homes, and repair shops.

These cornerstone industries in East Passyunk have seen steady growth over the past two decades. They account for two-thirds of the decade's employment growth. This shows East Passyunk's economic character has neither changed drastically nor stagnated. However, it is worth monitoring a sector that accounts for a much smaller share of East Passyunk's overall employment but is growing rapidly: Sector 71 saw 152% growth and is on track to become a basic industry.

10 Highest Changing Sectors 2013 to 2022

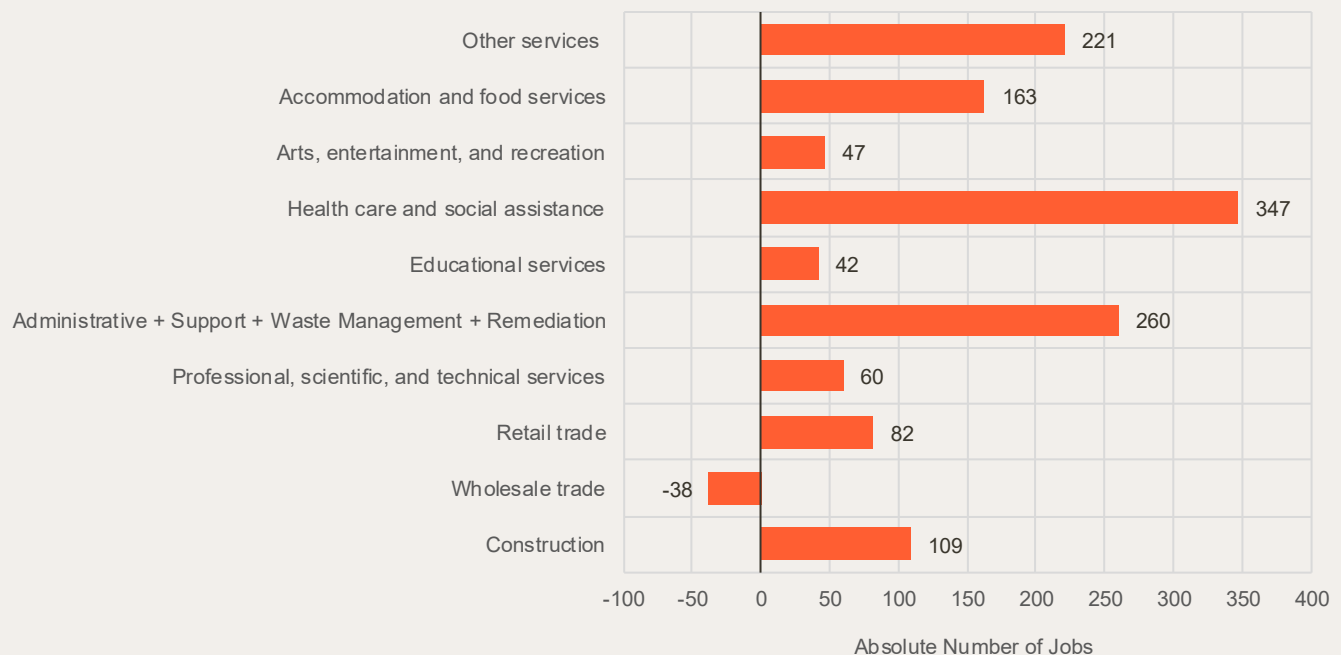


Figure 11

Employment Sectors

Only four sectors experienced an absolute decline from 2013 to 2022, and most of them had already had insignificant numbers of jobs in the first place, with perhaps an exception being Wholesale Trade, which declined by half, from ~80 jobs to ~40. However, we do see compositional changes that reveal sectors that are emerging or declining in relevance. The largest compositional decline was in Retail Trade, which fell from providing about 20% of jobs in East Passyunk in 2013 to 15% in 2022. Accommodation and food services also saw a significant compositional decline, from about 18% to 16% of jobs. Examining these two sectors together, we observe absolute growth in both; however, their compositional decline indicates that, in ordinary terms, shopping and dining are becoming somewhat less characteristic of East Passyunk's employment.

The economic growth and character of East Passyunk is not accidental but supported by highly local institutions such as the East Passyunk Avenue Business Improvement District, the Passyunk Avenue Revitalization Corporation, and the Bok Building (managed by design and development firm Scout Limited). While these all have slightly different roles and missions, they are all aimed at the services, retail, dining, and emerging arts sectors in East Passyunk, contributing to making it an economically distinct neighborhood.

There is a high concentration of the emerging creative industry in the Bok Building, which is home to over 600 jobs and a widely acclaimed redevelopment project (Blumgart, 2025). The Bok Building share of employment is on par with all of Broad Street and East Passyunk Avenue. The Bok Building was previously a vocational high school that the Philadelphia School Board closed in 2013 with a slate of other schools in an austerity move (Currie, 2021). However, the character of culinary, creative, and technical work has been consciously carried over in the Bok Building's new purpose. Additionally, it is more diverse than East Passyunk's population generally: "one in five [businesses] is owned by nonwhite tenants, and 56% of the businesses are owned by women. Almost half are devoted to arts and culture," and two-fifths of the workers live in South Philadelphia (Blumgart, 2025). Thus, this represents a recent venture that mitigates the changing character of the neighborhood by enabling minority-owned businesses and workers who live and work close by.



Residents vs. Workers

So far, we have discussed the economy in terms of the jobs located in East Passyunk, but overall, East Passyunk is more of a residential neighborhood that exports more workers than it imports on a day-to-day basis. Currently, 70% of eligible workers (individuals aged 16 and over) are employed, resulting in a fairly low unemployment rate of 4%, approximately half of the Philadelphia region's unemployment rate. From 2013 to 2023, the employed population increased by 2,300 workers, sparking a decline in the unemployed population by 950.

Figure 12 shows that residents of East Passyunk primarily work outside of the neighborhood, 40% in Center City or West Philadelphia, and overall, 82% work within Philadelphia. These employment trends are reflected in the types of industries East Passyunk residents work in as well. Twenty-nine percent of the workforce works in traditionally blue-collar jobs, such as construction, maintenance, and transportation. On the other hand, 71% of the workforce have white-collar jobs in management, business, science, and other office-based occupations. Since 2013, the number of people in management, business, and science has doubled, increasing by 23 percentage points from 34% to 57%.

Of those who work in East Passyunk, 9% commute from within the neighborhood, and another 19% commute from within South Philadelphia. This has been stable for the past decade, indicating that a large percentage of people working in East Passyunk find it both desirable and possible to live near where they work.

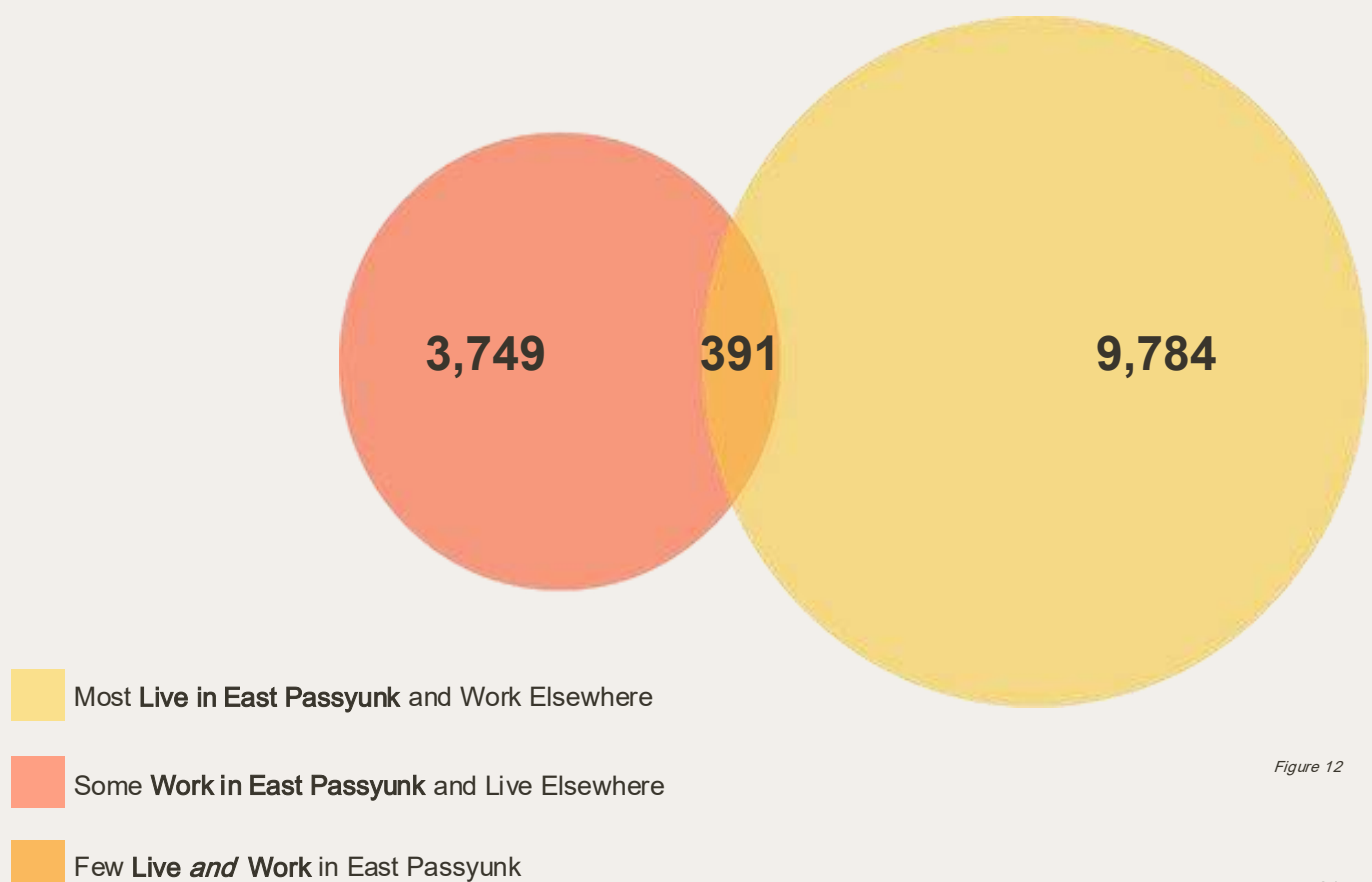


Figure 12

Income

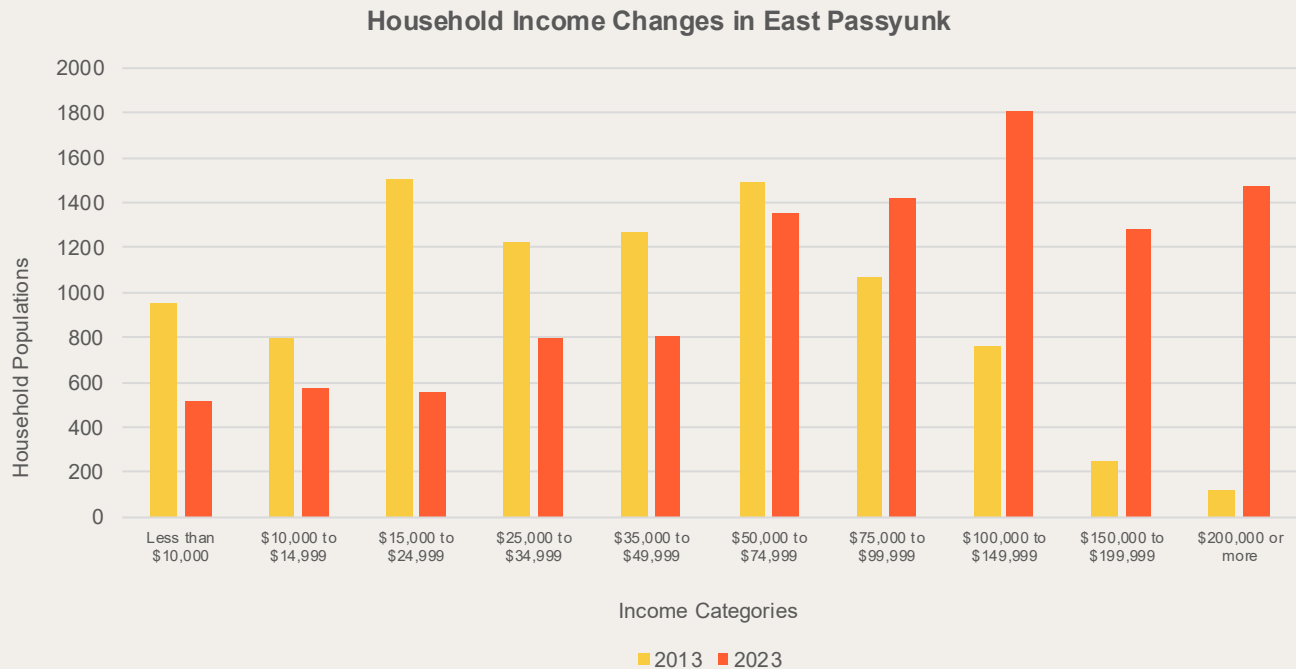


Figure 13

There is a notable difference between the incomes of those living and those working in East Passyunk. The majority of East Passyunk residents (60%) earn more than \$3,333 per month, while only 38% of East Passyunk workers earn more than \$3,333, and the majority earn less than that (62%). This helps paint a picture of East Passyunk's service and retail-oriented sectors which are likely designed to appeal to the patronage of the higher-income residents of East Passyunk, while providing lower pay. Since such a sizeable percentage of East Passyunk workers live nearby in South Philadelphia, housing, services, and amenities must remain affordable. Otherwise, the divide between residents and workers will widen and displace workers.

Focusing on East Passyunk residents, specifically, the mean household income is \$107,990. This is a 61% increase in average household income from 2013, which was \$67,166. This increase is also significant compared to Philadelphia, where the mean household income of the entire county is \$88,307. Figure 13 (above) depicts the number of households in each income bracket. From 2013 to 2023, each income bracket below \$75,000 decreases and each income bracket above increases which demonstrates that, on average, residents are overall making more money.

Income

Looking at another measure of central tendency in this data—the median income levels—requires diving into the Census tract-level data. Although residents in different Census tracts technically live in the same neighborhood, their incomes are vastly different. Of the five census tracts that comprise East Passyunk, Census Tract 41.01 has typically had the lowest median income, and Census Tract 29 has typically had the highest median income over the 10-year period. Figure 14 shows the median incomes of Census Tract 29, Census Tract 41.01, and Philadelphia County from 2013 to 2023 to get a sense of the range of wealth within the neighborhood compared to Philadelphia. In 2021, Census Tract 41.01's median income exceeded the median income of Philadelphia, which indicates that the neighborhood, on average, is getting wealthier. Both the lower bound and the upper bound of median income are greater than the median income in Philadelphia, which serves as further evidence that East Passyunk is becoming a wealthier neighborhood.

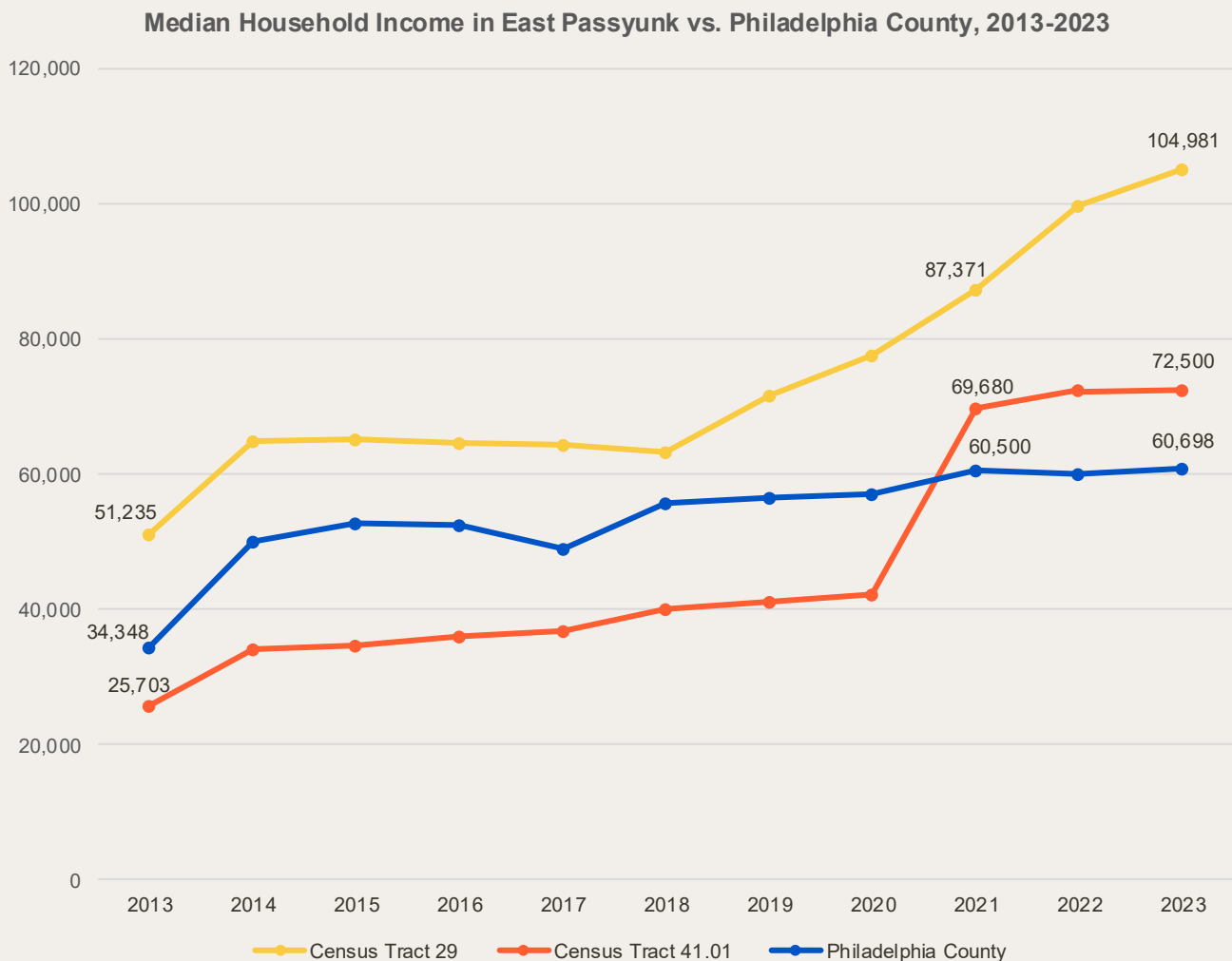


Figure 14

Income Inequality

People in East Passyunk seem to be better off financially in 2023 than in 2013, but these aggregate data and averages mask the income inequality that exists within the neighborhood. Given East Passyunk's diversity, analyzing racial differences in income is important as well. Figures 15 and 16 depict the distribution of household incomes in both 2013 and 2023 for white and Asian householders, respectively. White householders have generally become wealthier, in line with the trend of neighborhood median income increasing. On the other hand, Asian householders have seen more variance in income levels. Although there are wealth gains, there is still a large portion of the population making well below the median neighborhood income. These granular details provide deeper insight into how different groups experience financial changes.

Another group that has faced the brunt of income inequality is seniors. Of adults 65 and over, 17% are considered to be impoverished by the Census Bureau, which defines poverty as an individual's income being below the national poverty threshold. While the poverty rate of all other age groups has decreased, seniors are the only group that has seen an increase in poverty. Since there has been a decrease in the number of seniors, notably those 75 and above, it is possible that resources have been diverted towards groups that have seen increases in population (such as young adults and young children). Since older adults now make up a smaller share of the population, their poverty might not be given adequate attention.

Distribution of Household Incomes in 2013 and 2023, White Householder

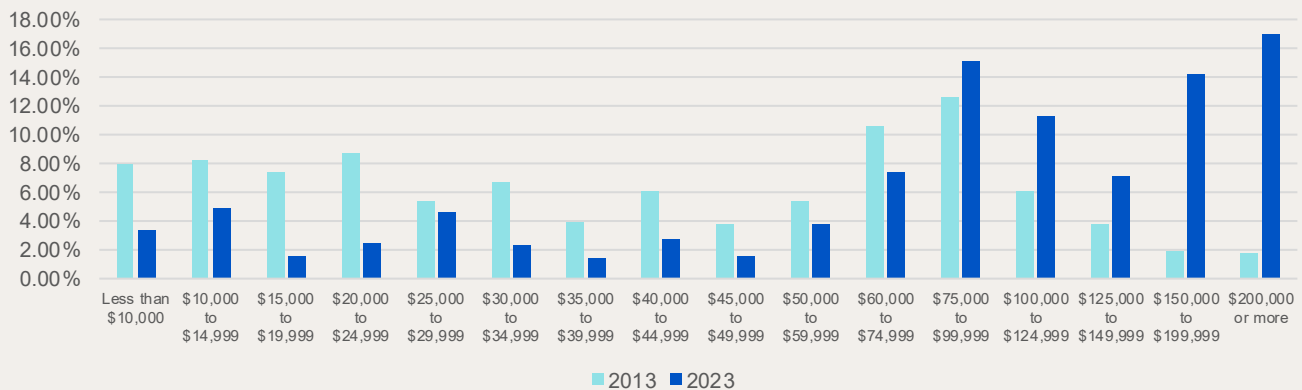


Figure 15

Distribution of Household Incomes in 2013 and 2023, Asian Householder

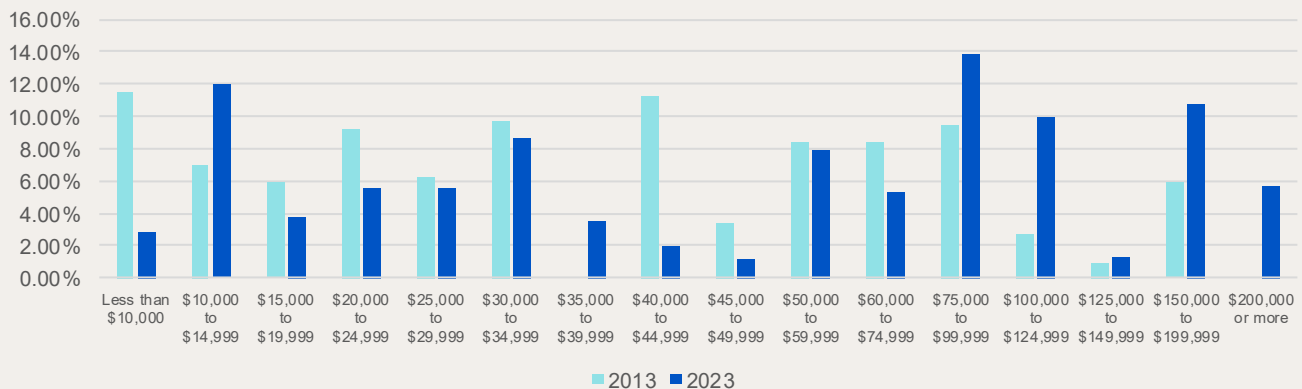
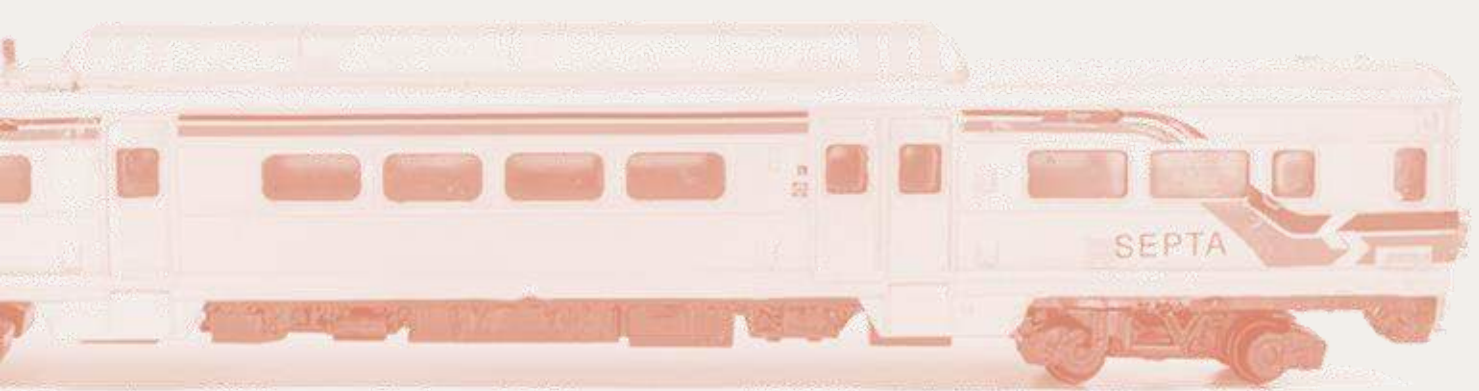


Figure 16

Commuting

A changing workforce is bringing about different commute mode shares. Currently, most of the working-age population drives alone in a car, truck, or van (27%), works from home (25%), or uses public transportation (24%). About 400 fewer people are utilizing public transportation in 2023 than in 2013, despite proximity to the Broad Street Line and several SEPTA bus lines.

The most notable commute mode change was with people working from home, which increased by 3,100 people and 23 percentage points. Although this is an expected shift due to the COVID-19 pandemic, work from home has increased by over 2100%. Compared to Philadelphia, individuals working from home are overrepresented in East Passyunk by a factor of 1.5. The populations that have the highest share of people working from home include white (69%), non-immigrants (83%), who are 25-to-44 years old (68%), working in management, business, science, and arts occupations (71%), and earning more than \$75,000 (44%). This new commute mode shift is evidenced by industry change, where educational services, health care, and professional management services both experienced over 55% growth and had the highest share of remote workers (49%). Commuting patterns shift in tandem with occupational changes, where white-collar occupations provide the option of working from home, whereas more manual labor does not.



The higher-income professionals who work from home represent a remote brain drain and their employment is not captured locally.

Economic Projection

Looking towards the next decade, we predict an increase of 2,462 jobs in East Passyunk. We produced this estimate using a shift-share analysis wherein we kept the macro national growth factor, industry competitiveness, and local competitiveness constant as they were for the past decade. This is a projected employment increase of 60%. East Passyunk's basic industries are projected to comprise 1,583, or over two-thirds of these new jobs, which will support 1.6 total jobs in the neighborhood. The highest growth rates are predicted for Sector 81 (1.5 growth rate), Sector 71 (1.18 growth rate), and Sector 56 (1.16 growth rate), and the driving force of these high growth rates is local competitiveness in these industries. This is encouraging, seeing as East Passyunk is already on track to support and promote the rising creative and service industries through business associations and projects like the Bok Building.

Basic Industries in East Passyunk

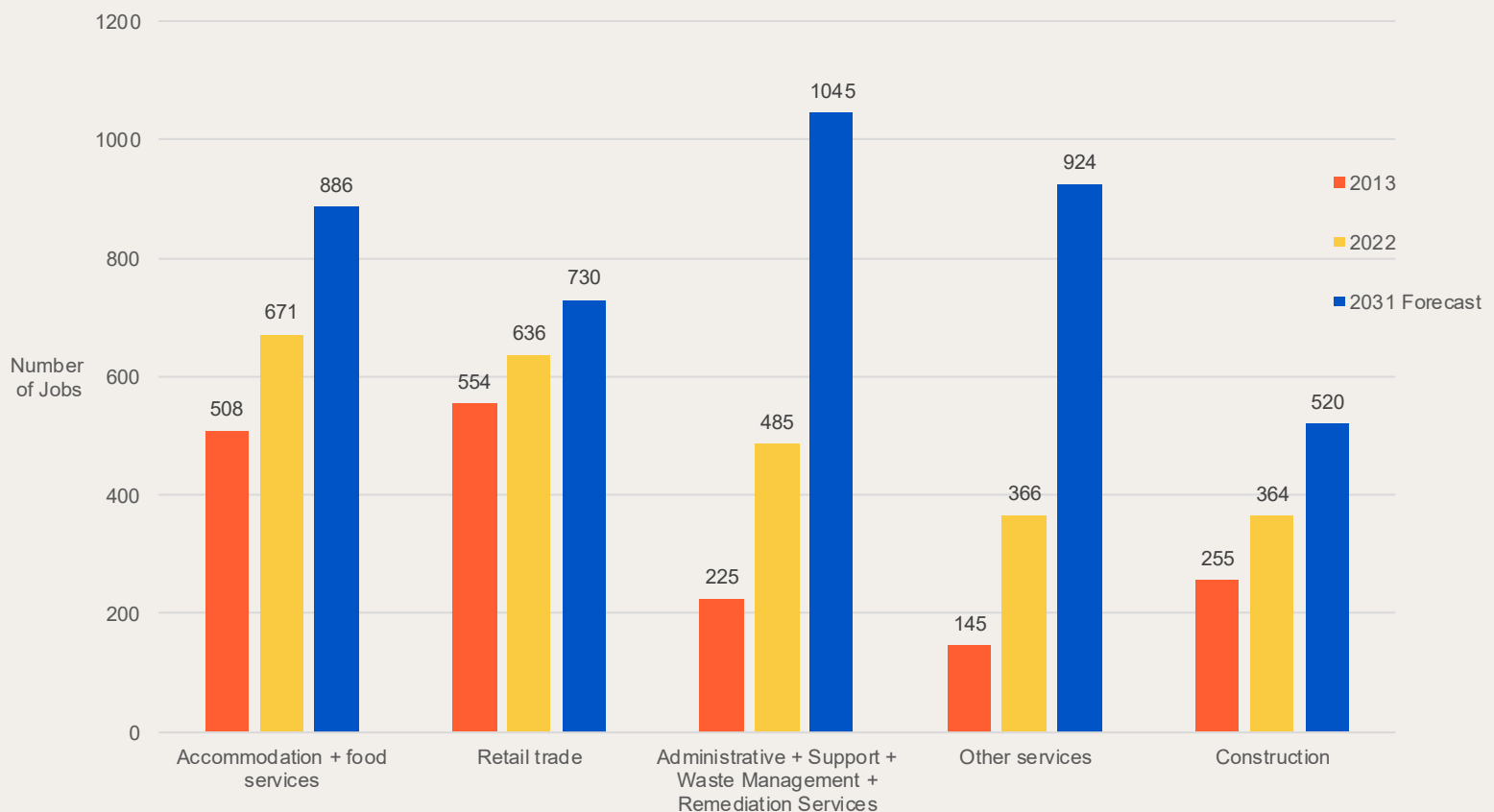


Figure 17

Challenges & Opportunities

East Passyunk are facing pertinent challenges: rising housing needs and displacement risks, shrinking space for immigrants and low-income households, and younger, more educated families, but a deficiency of schools and care. These concerns shape East Passyunk's present and potential future.

Challenges & Opportunities

Equity

CHALLENGE

Guarding Against a Poverty-Outmigration Cycle

Demographic changes in East Passyunk are generating increased pressures on equity, which are most visibly apparent through the decline of long-time immigrant and racial minority populations. These shrinking groups tend to be economically more vulnerable, which means that structural disadvantages can be masked by improving incomes and housing values. As higher income residents move in and secure access to better resources, the benefits are less likely to be shared evenly, and vulnerable residents face rising risks of being priced out. This could create a negative feedback loop where poverty accelerates outmigration leaving vulnerable groups underrepresented and overlooked in East Passyunk.

OPPORTUNITY

An Inclusive Retention and Re-Attraction Strategy

East Passyunk's immigrant roots have not disappeared. The shares of foreign-born residents and non-English speakers in the neighborhood remain more concentrated than citywide, suggesting there is still a foundation for policy intervention to stabilize the remaining population and rebuild equitable attraction. The neighborhood should strengthen the opportunities, resources, and services that support immigrant residents at risk of leaving by expanding workforce programs and improving overall affordable and social livability. This includes job training, English literacy classes, and more inclusive community programming that strengthens social integration and belonging.

Accessibility

Insufficient Support For Specific Age Cohorts

East Passyunk's neighborhood resources are increasingly oriented toward young families. While the 1-to-5 and 35-to-45 age groups are growing, the 75 and above population is declining, and residents aged 5-24 are less concentrated than citywide, all signaling that the neighborhood is increasingly becoming more accommodating for young families, but less supportive for teenagers and older adults. As children progress further through their schooling experience, families may move out due to limited education opportunities and youth recreational activity, while older residents may struggle to remain because of housing constraints, limited-service accessibility, or insufficient neighborhood-based support.

Creating an Age-Inclusive Environment

East Passyunk needs to build a support system for all ages, as the demographic shifts show who is leaving and staying. This exemplifies the need to address demands of underserved age groups. This support includes planning ahead for increased school capacity and integration and advocating city investment into the strong growing youth base. This can bridge the school age gap and prevent families from moving out. Simultaneously, expanding age-friendly support, such as accessibility upgrades and improved proximity to health-oriented services enables aging in place. This can transform today's growth in future young family retention, stronger neighborhood resilience and improved quality of life for all ages.

Challenges & Opportunities

Housing

CHALLENGE

The 2030 Housing Shortfall and Affordability Crisis

East Passyunk is projected to require approximately 1,479 additional housing units by 2030, meaning that if supply does not keep pace with this forecast, today's housing tightness will turn into a structural deficit. In this context, the most immediate challenge is that housing costs are more likely to rise, concentrating pressure on lower-income households. Over time, this can increase outmigration risk for populations unable to afford living expenses and undermine the neighborhood's long-term livability and social stability.

OPPORTUNITY

Setting Delivery Targets and Tying Growth to Affordability

This quantified projection provides clear policy guidance. East Passyunk should move away from subdividing existing housing stock and instead transform projected housing demand into explicit new-unit delivery targets. Additionally, new development policies should focus on increasing the share of inclusionary affordable units and expanding the supply of unit types that can cater to small and medium size households. This approach would both support lower-income residents and better match the trend toward smaller household sizes, helping the neighborhood absorb growth without accelerating and influencing more outmigration.

Economy

Rising Livability Concerns Within a Service-Driven Local Economy

As the neighborhood increasingly caters to higher-income residents and visitors, including a large population working from home, many of the workers who sustain the neighborhood's retail, food, and other services are more likely to have lower pay and are at risk of being priced out. Over time, this can also reduce service quality and reliability as commuting burdens increase, and turnover rises, making it harder for small businesses to maintain stability. This resident-worker divide can destabilize the local service workforce and weaken the long-run resilience of the local businesses, everyday street life, and the community in the neighborhood.

Diversification with shared gains for workers and residents

East Passyunk is showing signs of economic diversification and new growth engines beyond the traditional shopping and dining modes. The neighborhood is seeing growth in creative and recreational activities that are supported by locally anchored programming such as the BID and Bok. The neighborhood should connect this growth to inclusive job opportunities, while exploring ways to share local commercial gains with the workers. Also, keeping living conditions affordable is important to truly support low-income residents and workers. This can be done through reliable commuting access and worker discount partnerships that reduce the cost of everyday essentials.

References

References

Blumgart, J. (2025). "At Its 10th Anniversary, the Bok Building Boasts Its Economic Impact." The Philadelphia Inquirer. <https://www.inquirer.com/real-estate/commercial/bok-building-economic-impact-lindsey-scannapieco-20250908.html>.

Bureau of Labor Statistics (2013). QCEW NAICS-Based Data Files. <https://www.bls.gov/cew/downloadable-data-files.htm>

Bureau of Labor Statistics (2022). QCEW NAICS-Based Data Files. <https://www.bls.gov/cew/downloadable-data-files.htm>

Currie, N (2021). "A Closed Vocational School Became Home to Hundreds of Small Businesses. Could It Be Replicated Elsewhere?" Grid Magazine. <https://gridphilly.com/blog-home/2021/11/25/a-closed-vocational-school-became-home-to-hundreds-of-small-businesses-could-it-be-replicated-elsewhere/>.

Dent, M. (2015). East Passyunk Guide: The Avenue, the restaurants and how Frank Sinatra got to be 'Ol' Blue Eyes' BillyPenn at WHYY. <https://billypenn.com/2015/01/14/east-passyunk-guide-the-avenue-the-restaurants-and-how-frank-sinatra-got-to-be-ol-blue-eyes/>

East Passyunk Avenue Business Improvement District. (n.d.). *East Passyunk Avenue*. <https://www.visiteastpassyunk.com/>

East Passyunk Avenue Business Improvement District. (n.d.). *Our history*. <https://www.visiteastpassyunk.com/>

East Passyunk Historical Street Scenes. Public Art Archive. <https://publicartarchive.org/art/East-Passyunk-Historical-Street-Scenes/7c8af24f>.

South Philadelphia. The Encyclopedia of Greater Philadelphia. <https://philadelphiaencyclopedia.org/locations/south-philadelphia/>

U.S. Census Bureau. (2013). *LEHD origin–destination employment statistics (LODES)*. <https://lehd.ces.census.gov/data/lodes>

U.S. Census Bureau. (2022). *LEHD origin–destination employment statistics (LODES)*. <https://lehd.ces.census.gov/data/lodes>

U.S. Census Bureau. (n.d.). *Selected social characteristics in the United States* (American Community Survey, 5-year estimates, Table DP02). Retrieved December 14, 2025, from <https://data.census.gov/table/ACSDP5Y2013.DP02>

U.S. Census Bureau. (n.d.). *Selected economic characteristics* (American Community Survey, 5-year estimates, Table DP03). Retrieved December 14, 2025, from <https://data.census.gov/table/ACSDP5Y2013.DP03>

U.S. Census Bureau. (n.d.). *Selected housing characteristics* (American Community Survey, 5-year estimates, Table DP04). Retrieved December 14, 2025, from <https://data.census.gov/table/ACSDP5Y2013.DP04>

References

U.S. Census Bureau. (n.d.). *ACS demographic and housing estimates* (American Community Survey, 5-year estimates, Table DP05). Retrieved December 14, 2025, from <https://data.census.gov/table/ACSDP5Y2013.DP05>

U.S. Census Bureau. (n.d.). *Selected social characteristics in the United States* (American Community Survey, 5-year estimates, Table DP02). Retrieved December 14, 2025, from <https://data.census.gov/table/ACSDP5Y2023.DP02>

U.S. Census Bureau. (n.d.). *Selected economic characteristics* (American Community Survey, 5-year estimates, Table DP03). Retrieved December 14, 2025, from <https://data.census.gov/table/ACSDP5Y2023.DP03>

U.S. Census Bureau. (n.d.). *Selected housing characteristics* (American Community Survey, 5-year estimates, Table DP04). Retrieved December 14, 2025, from <https://data.census.gov/table/ACSDP5Y2023.DP04>

U.S. Census Bureau. (n.d.). *ACS demographic and housing estimates* (American Community Survey, 5-year estimates, Table DP05). Retrieved December 14, 2025, from <https://data.census.gov/table/ACSDP5Y2023.DP05>